

WHAT IS CYBERCRIME?

How to recognise it, what it costs, and how to protect yourself • LEVEL B



Cybercriminals use a wide range of sophisticated techniques to target individuals, companies, and governments around the world.

Cybercrime is criminal activity that either targets or uses a computer, a computer network, or a networked device. Most cybercrime is carried out by cybercriminals or hackers who are motivated by financial gain. However, cybercrime can also be politically or personally motivated, and its targets range from individual users to large corporations and even government systems. Some cybercriminals are highly organised, technically skilled, and well-resourced. Others are **novice hackers** who use freely available tools with limited technical knowledge.

What Are the Main Types of Cybercrime?

Email & Internet **Fraud**

Using deceptive emails or websites to trick people into giving away money or personal details.

Ransomware / **Cyberextortion**

Locking a victim's files or device and demanding payment — usually in cryptocurrency — to restore access.

Phishing Campaigns

Sending fake messages designed to trick recipients into revealing passwords or clicking malicious links.

Identity Fraud

Stealing personal information and using it to impersonate someone, often to access their finances.

Malware Attacks

Installing harmful software on a device to steal data, cause damage, or take control of the system.

Cyberespionage

Secretly accessing government or corporate systems to steal confidential information for political purposes.

Cryptojacking

Using someone else's computer resources without permission to mine cryptocurrency for profit.

DDoS Attacks

Flooding a website or network with traffic to overwhelm it and prevent legitimate users from accessing it.

How Does Cybercrime Actually Work?

Cybercrime generally falls into two broad categories. The first involves using **malware** — harmful software such as viruses, spyware, or **ransomware** — to directly attack a computer or network. Once a device is **compromised**, criminals can steal **confidential** data, delete files, spy on the user, or use the machine to carry out further attacks on other systems. The second category involves using computers as a tool to commit crimes such as **fraud**, spreading illegal content, or running large-scale **phishing** campaigns. In many cases, cybercriminals do both at once: they **infiltrate** a system with malware first, and then use that system to attack others.

Some jurisdictions also recognise a third category, where a computer is used as an accessory to a crime — for example, using a laptop simply to store stolen data. It is also worth noting that **cybercrime** is rarely limited to one country. Attacks can be launched from anywhere in the world, which creates significant challenges for law enforcement agencies trying to identify and prosecute those responsible.

Famous Examples of Cybercrime

■ CASE STUDY 1 — The WannaCry Ransomware Attack (2017)

In May 2017, a **ransomware** attack known as WannaCry spread rapidly across the world, affecting 230,000 computers in 150 countries. The **malware** exploited a **vulnerability** in computers running Microsoft Windows — a weakness in the software that had not yet been patched. Once a device was infected, users were locked out of their files and received a message demanding a Bitcoin ransom to regain access. The attack caused an estimated \$4 billion in financial losses worldwide and disrupted hospitals, businesses, and government systems. To this day, WannaCry stands out for its sheer scale and impact.

■ CASE STUDY 2 — The World Cup Phishing Scam (2018)

During the 2018 FIFA World Cup in Russia, a large-scale **phishing** campaign targeted football fans around the world. Criminals sent spam emails offering fake free trips to Moscow, where the tournament was being hosted. Fans who clicked on the links contained in these emails had their personal data stolen. This is a classic example of how phishing campaigns exploit major public events to trick large numbers of people simultaneously. A more targeted version of this technique, known as **spear-phishing**, involves crafting messages that appear to come from a trusted source — such as a company CEO or IT manager — in order to **infiltrate** a specific organisation.

+31%

rise in security attacks from 2020 to 2021

\$200K

average cost of a single cyber attack on a company

\$56B

identity fraud losses in the US in 2021 alone

The Impact of Cybercrime

Cybercrime is on the rise. According to Accenture's State of Cybersecurity Resilience report, security attacks increased by 31% between 2020 and 2021, with the average number of attacks per company rising from 206 to 270 per year. A single attack — whether it is a **data breach**, **malware** infection, **ransomware**, or a **DDoS attack** — costs companies an average of \$200,000. Alarmingly, many businesses affected by a serious cyber attack go out

of business within six months of the incident.

The impact is not limited to financial damage. For both individuals and companies, **cybercrime** can cause serious **reputational** harm — once customers lose trust in an organisation's ability to protect their data, that trust is very difficult to regain. A study by Javelin Strategy and Research found that **identity fraud** losses in the United States alone totalled \$56 billion in 2021. Given the growing **prevalence** of cybercrime, understanding how to protect yourself is no longer optional — it is an essential life skill.

How to Protect Yourself Against Cybercrime

There are several practical steps you can take to significantly reduce your risk of becoming a victim of **cybercrime**. None of them require advanced technical knowledge — but all of them require awareness and consistent good habits.

1

Keep software updated

Always install the latest software updates and security patches. Updates fix known vulnerabilities that criminals actively look for and exploit.

2

Use strong, unique passwords

Use a different password for every account and make each one long and difficult to guess. A reputable password manager can help you do this automatically.

3

Never open suspicious attachments

Malware is frequently spread through email attachments. Never open a file from a sender you do not recognise, even if the email looks **legitimate**.

4

Check URLs carefully

Before clicking a link, check whether the web address looks genuine. Criminals often create fake websites with addresses very similar to the real ones.

5

Protect your personal data

Never give out passwords, banking details, or personal information over the phone or email unless you are completely certain the request is **legitimate**.

6

Monitor your bank statements

Check your bank and card statements regularly. If you spot a transaction you do not recognise, contact your bank immediately — acting quickly can limit the damage.

■ IMPORTANT — If you think you are being targeted

If a company contacts you unexpectedly and asks for personal information or payment, hang up or do not reply. Call the company back using the number from their official website — not the number they gave you. Cybercriminals can keep phone lines open and pretend to be the same organisation when you call back, so ideally use a different device.

ACTIVITIES

1 Read the article and decide if these statements are True (T), False (F), or Not Given (NG).

- 1 All cybercriminals are highly skilled and technically advanced.
- 2 The WannaCry attack affected computers in more than 100 countries.
- 3 The World Cup phishing scam only targeted people who bought tickets.
- 4 A single cyber attack costs businesses an average of \$200,000.
- 5 Identity fraud losses in the US totalled \$56 billion in 2021.
- 6 Installing software updates can help protect against known vulnerabilities.

2 Match the highlighted words in the article to their meanings.

- 1 harmful software designed to damage or gain access to a computer system
- 2 a weakness in software that can be exploited by attackers
- 3 a targeted phishing attack designed to trick a specific individual or organisation
- 4 to secretly enter a system or organisation without permission
- 5 the quality of being well-known and respected; damage to this is hard to repair
- 6 how common or widespread something is

3 Read the article again and answer these questions in full sentences.

- 1 What is the difference between the two main categories of cybercrime?
- 2 Why did the WannaCry attack spread so quickly and cause so much damage?
- 3 How does spear-phishing differ from a standard phishing campaign?
- 4 Beyond financial loss, what other damage can cybercrime cause to a company?
- 5 According to the article, why is understanding cybercrime now an 'essential life skill'?

4 Discussion: Imagine you work for a school's IT department. Write a short guide (80–100 words) advising students on how to stay safe online.

Use vocabulary and ideas from the article.

Think about: passwords, emails, links, personal data, and what to do if targeted.

■ TALKING POINTS

Do you think individuals or companies are more responsible for preventing cybercrime?

Why do you think cybercrime has increased so significantly in recent years?

Should governments be allowed to monitor internet activity to prevent cybercrime? Where is the line?

Have you or anyone you know ever been targeted by a phishing attempt? What happened?